

that had live music or music festivals. I didn't know anyone who had travelled to Delhi, Pune or Mumbai and could tell me about the music scene in those cities. I was very lucky that my parents let me chart my own course." Being the first runner-up in the inaugural All India Finger-Style Guitar Competition in 2014 definitely helped. "Even though I didn't win, my name was in the newspapers in Arunachal. My family was proud of me and it proved that I was very dedicated to music." ■

–Karishma Upadhyay

MUSIC

ALL ABOUT **JAZZ**

This weekend **NCPA's Tata Theatre** in Mumbai will come alive to the sounds of top-notch international jazz acts

The NCPA International Jazz Festival 2024, from November 22 to 24 at the Tata Theatre in Mumbai, promises an exciting line-up that celebrates jazz's global reach. This year's festival is set to bring together Grammy-winning artists, child prodigies and icons from the jazz world for three nights of unforgettable performances.

Farrahnaz Irani, general manager - international music, at NCPA, explains that curating the line-up is a year-round effort. "After an initial screening process, we draw up a list of artists who match our interest and style of jazz. Upon further discussion and deliberation, four to six artists are shortlisted, and negotiations with the artists' management begin." This lengthy process ensures a line-up that reflects NCPA's high standards, with the 2024 festival showcasing talents like Brandon Goldberg, Gonzalo Rubalcaba, Matthew Whitaker, and Veronica Swift.



Irani sees the NCPA's role as essential in cultivating an audience for genres like jazz in India. While international musicians are increasingly visiting India, most are pop artists popularised through social media. In contrast, the NCPA focuses on bringing mature genres like jazz to India, giving local audiences an opportunity to engage with exceptional musicianship. "The NCPA has always been India's premier art and cultural centre, with an aim to expose the city and now other metropolitan cities to varied genres of music," she says. Recent performances from icons like Dianne Reeves, Jesús Molina, Emmet Cohen and Herbie Hancock exemplify this mission.

Budget constraints pose a challenge in organising the festival. "With international artists come international fees, and hence budgets are always a challenge," notes Irani. However, she views this as a chance to showcase NCPA's world-class auditoriums and connect artists with India's unique cultural spirit. "Every artist who has performed with us wants to come back and introduce more artists to the NCPA," she adds.

This year's line-up reflects the NCPA's dedication to excellence. On November 22, Goldberg will open the festival with his trio. Known for his performances at events like the Newport Jazz Festival, the prodigy will perform alongside top musicians. Rubalcaba, a Grammy-winning pianist and Latin jazz visionary, takes the stage on November 23, joined by Ernesto Simpson on drums and Ricardo 'Ricky' Rodriguez on bass. The final night features Matthew Whitaker, a multi-instrumental virtuoso, followed by Veronica Swift, a rising star celebrated for her versatile vocal talent. ■

–Nikhil Sardana







GROOVE MAESTROS
Clockwise from above, Veronica Swift, Gonzalo Rubalcaba, Matthew Whitaker and Brandon Goldberg